

A FRAMEWORK IN CHAPTERS

Chapter Four

Kinship Normativity

*The system that ranks blood and marriage
above all other forms of relation*

Kinship Normativity is the system that ranks blood and marriage relations above all other relations, enforces 'real family' as the only legitimate form of kinship, and removes the option to build kinship outside blood and marriage. This chapter runs it through the five domains — from the compound to the Marriage Act to the slow death of the childless woman who believes she is incomplete.

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CHAPTER 4 OF AN ONGOING FRAMEWORK

Kinship Normativity

Kinship Normativity overlaps with Adultism at the parent-child dyad and with Cisheteropatriarchy at the marriage dyad. But the three matrices are not the same. Adultism ranks by age.

Cisheteropatriarchy ranks by gender and sexuality. Kinship Normativity ranks by blood and marriage — the privileging of biological and conjugal relation above every other form of human connection.

The framework separates them so that the kinship logic specifically can be studied and dismantled. Kinship Normativity is what makes the chosen family illegitimate, the adopted child treated as second-best, the childless woman pitied, and the unmarried adult a failure. It is the system that decides who counts as ‘real’ family.

A note on method. The Interpersonal, Disciplinary, and Structural sections take the naive approach — each triad described as if happening for the first time, with no networks, residues, or Canon referenced. The Hegemonic Domain section is where Canon and Practice finally enter the picture.

READING NOTE

Same convention as Chapters 1, 2, and 3. Every paragraph is written to be tweetable. Where you see literal blanks (____), the framework is asking you to write yourself into it. The blanks are the difference between reading about Kinship Normativity and locating yourself inside it.

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SECTION 1

1. Definition: What Kinship Normativity Extracts, Enforces, and Removes

Kinship Normativity is the system that ranks blood and marriage relations above all other relations, enforces ‘real family’ as the only legitimate form of kinship, and removes the option to build kinship outside blood and marriage. The term is borrowed from queer theory — Judith Butler’s *Is Kinship Always Already Heterosexual?* (2002) and Kath Weston’s *Families We Choose* (1991) are the foundational texts.

The framework uses the term as a fundamental matrix in its own right. Kinship Normativity is what makes blood a moral category. The anthropologist David Schneider argued in *A Critique of the Study of Kinship* (1984) that ‘kinship’ itself is a folk category dressed up as an analytical one — that the privileging of blood is not a discovery of anthropology but an imposition.

In Nigeria, Ifi Amadiume’s *Male Daughters, Female Husbands* (1987) and Nkiru Nzegwu’s *Family Matters* (2006) showed that pre-colonial Nigerian kinship systems were markedly more flexible than the colonial import. The Igbo female husband, the male daughter, fostering as normal, polygyny as recognised — these were not deviations from a natural order but features of a different arrangement. Kinship Normativity names what displaced them.

1.1 What Kinship Normativity Extracts

Kinship Normativity extracts five things. First, **loyalty**: the allegiance owed to family that takes priority over allegiance to friends, partners, colleagues, or self. Second, **caretaking labour**: the unpaid physical and emotional care that family members owe each other, especially elders to be cared for by the young.

Third, **financial support**: the contributions family members owe the family unit — school fees for younger siblings, hospital bills for parents, festive contributions, remittances. Fourth, **inheritance channelling**: the channelling of property, names, and status through blood lines, excluding those outside the line.

Fifth, **reproductive capacity**: the production of heirs to carry the family name and lineage. The childless person is failed; the person who refuses to reproduce is selfish; the person who reproduces outside marriage has produced an ‘illegitimate’ child. Each of these is tangible and consequential.

1.2 What Kinship Normativity Enforces

Kinship Normativity enforces four standards. First, the **blood standard**: blood relation is the primary and irreducible form of kinship. Adopted and step relations are secondary. Friends are not family.

Chosen relations are not kin. Second, the **marriage standard**: marriage is the only legitimate conjugal relation. Cohabitation is suspect. Outside marriage is ‘living in sin.’

Third, the **family name standard**: the family name is carried by blood and marriage. Women take the husband’s name on marriage (this overlaps with Cisheteropatriarchy, Chapter 5). Children take the father’s name. The name is the lineage. Fourth, the **filial piety standard**: obedience and deference to family elders regardless of the elder’s merit. The family is the unit; the individual is a member.

1.3 What Options Kinship Normativity Removes

Concretely, Kinship Normativity removes the option of chosen family with legal recognition. The friend who has been your primary support for twenty years cannot make medical decisions for you when you are incapacitated. The blood relative you have not seen in fifteen years can. The law recognises the blood, not the relation.

It removes the option of non-biological parenting without bureaucracy. The stepparent who has raised a child since infancy has no legal relationship to that child without a formal adoption. The foster parent who has loved a child for ten years has no inheritance rights to leave the child. Adoption in Nigeria requires court proceedings, social worker reports, and consent hurdles that blood parents never face.

It removes the option to refuse family obligations. The eldest son who refuses to pay his younger siblings’ school fees is shunned. The daughter who refuses to nurse her ailing mother is shunned. The childless woman who refuses to attend the family Christmas is shunned. Each refusal carries social cost; many carry legal cost.

It removes the option to leave the family. Disownment is rare in legal terms but common in practice. The LGBTQ+ Nigerian who comes out is disowned by family with no legal recourse. The woman who leaves an abusive husband is told to return ‘for the children’ and ‘for the family.’ The man who marries outside his ethnic group is cut off. The framework will examine each removal in the domains below.

SECTION 2 · NAIVE APPROACH

2. The Interpersonal Domain

The Interpersonal Domain contains four enforcement triads and five extraction triads. Each is described here as if happening for the first time — no networks, no residues, no Canon. Just the act, the conforming subject, the complicit witness, and (for extraction triads) the Non-Extracting Beneficiary.

3.1 Enforcement Triad: Blood Standard

The enforcer is the person who demands recognition of blood relation as the primary and irreducible form of kinship. A parent, a sibling, an extended relative, or an institution's representative could fill this role. The enforcement is performed by invoking blood ('blood is thicker than water'), by correcting non-blood kinship claims ('she's not your real sister'), or by punishing those who treat non-blood relations as primary.

The subject conforms by treating blood relations as primary. The conforming act is the priority itself — the subject chooses the blood relation over the non-blood relation when the two compete. The choosing is the enforcement.

The options the subject loses are concrete. A person who treats their best friend as their primary kin loses the right to introduce that friend as 'family' without social cost. A person who treats their adopted sibling as 'real' loses the right to be shielded from relatives who insist on the qualifier. A person who refuses to recognise a toxic blood relative loses the right to family support, sometimes to family inheritance, sometimes to physical safety.

The witness is the person who hears the blood invocation and says nothing, or who themselves invoke blood in their own kinship claims. The witness's complicity is structural: their silence tells the enforcer that the demand is legitimate, and tells the subject that blood priority is the natural order.

3.2 Enforcement Triad: Marriage Standard

The enforcer is the person who demands recognition of marriage as the only legitimate conjugal relation. A parent, a religious leader, a relative, or an institution's representative could fill this role. The enforcement is performed by asking 'when are you getting married?', by referring to cohabitation as 'living in sin', by refusing to recognise the unmarried partner at family events, or by punishing those who treat non-marital relations as legitimate.

The subject conforms by marrying, by hiding the non-marital relation, or by treating the non-marital relation as secondary. The conforming act is the marriage itself in the first case; in the second and third cases, the conforming act is the suppression.

The options the subject loses are concrete. A cohabiting couple loses the right to inherit from each other without a will, the right to make medical decisions for each other, the right to be buried together, the right to spousal benefits under pension and insurance law. A polyamorous person loses the right to have any of their relations recognised. A single person loses the right to be treated as complete.

The witness is the person who hears the marriage enforcement and says nothing, or who themselves model compliance by being married or by aspiring to marriage. The witness's complicity normalises the demand. The married witness at the wedding who congratulates the couple on 'finally making it official' is closing the loop.

3.3 Enforcement Triad: Family Name Standard

The enforcer is the person who demands the family name be carried by blood and marriage. The patriarch who demands the grandson carry his name. The mother-in-law who demands the daughter-in-law take her son's name. The father who refuses to allow his daughter to keep her maiden name. The enforcement is performed by direct demand, by social pressure, or by withholding recognition from those who do not carry the name.

The subject conforms by carrying the name, by giving the name to children, or by taking the spouse's name on marriage. The conforming act is the name itself — the name is the lineage, the lineage is the name. There is no argument to make against a name demand that has already been met by the name on the form.

The options the subject loses are concrete. A woman who takes her husband's name loses the right to be identified by her own lineage, which is to say, loses the right to professional continuity under her birth name. A child who does not carry the father's name loses inheritance rights under some customary systems. A person who changes their name for non-marriage reasons loses the right to be recognised by their lineage at all.

The witness is the person who watches the name enforcement and does not intervene, or who themselves carry the family name and so model compliance. The witness's complicity is the shared acceptance that the name is the lineage and the lineage is the name.

3.4 Enforcement Triad: Filial Piety Standard

The enforcer is the person who demands obedience and deference to family elders. The parent who demands the adult child attend the family event. The grandparent who demands the grandchild greet them in the prescribed way. The family elder who demands the younger relative accept the arranged marriage. The enforcement is performed by direct command, by guilt ('after all I did for you'), or by threatening disownment.

The subject conforms by obeying, by attending, by performing the prescribed greeting, by accepting the arrangement. The conforming act is the obedience itself — the young person does what they were told, even if they disagree, even if the instruction harms them, even if no reason was given.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The adult daughter who is told ‘but she’s your mother’ loses the right to refuse contact with an abusive parent. The adult son who is told ‘the family needs you’ loses the right to refuse financial support to siblings who are adults themselves. The young woman who is told ‘this is the husband we have chosen’ loses the right to choose her own partner.

The witness is the person who watches the filial piety enforcement and does not intervene, or who themselves performed the same obedience for the same elders. The witness’s complicity is the shared ‘I did it too’ that closes the loop.

3.5 Extraction Triad: Loyalty

The extractor is the person who requires loyalty to the family above every other allegiance. The parent who demands the adult child vote for the family’s political candidate. The sibling who demands the sister side with them in a family dispute regardless of merit. The family elder who demands the younger relative attend the family event over a friend’s wedding. The extraction is performed by invoking ‘family comes first’ or by punishing disloyalty.

The subject conforms by being loyal. What is extracted is the allegiance itself — the energy spent in defence of the family, the time spent at family events, the cognitive work of prioritising family in every decision. The loyalty is invisible as labour because it is performed as love.

The options the subject loses are concrete. Every hour spent in loyalty performance is an hour not spent on the subject’s own relationships, work, or rest. Over years, the cumulative loss is the option to develop one’s own allegiances, one’s own judgment, one’s own life outside the family. The loyal subject becomes the kind of person who cannot imagine refusing the family, even when refusal would save them.

The witness is the person who watches the loyalty extraction and does not intervene, or who themselves performed the same loyalty for the same family. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the family member who consumes the loyalty — the sibling who benefits from the loyal sister’s defence, the cousin who benefits from the loyal relative’s attendance — but who does not personally demand it.

The role is unstable. The moment the sibling or cousin begins to demand loyalty for themselves, they become extractors. Most family members drift into extraction over time, because the felt entitlement grows with each received loyalty performance.

3.6 Extraction Triad: Caretaking Labour

The extractor is the person who requires the family member to provide unpaid physical and emotional care. The ageing parent who requires the daughter to nurse them. The ill sibling who requires the sister to manage their household. The grandparent who requires the grandchild to provide daily care. The extraction is performed by expectation, by guilt, or by direct command.

The subject conforms by caretaking. What is extracted is the labour of physical and emotional care — feeding, bathing, lifting, listening, soothing, absorbing. The labour is real. It is the same labour adults

perform in paid care work, except the family member is not paid and cannot leave.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The 35-year-old daughter nursing her mother loses the option to take a job in another city, which is to say, loses the option to a career. The teenage granddaughter lifting her grandfather loses the option to a teenage body that is not already worn out. The sibling managing the household of an ill brother loses the option to a household of their own.

The witness is the person who watches the caretaking extraction and does not intervene, or who themselves performed the same labour for the same relatives. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the family member who is not directly commanding the care but who benefits from it — the brother whose mother is being nursed by the sister, freeing him from the work.

3.7 Extraction Triad: Financial Support

The extractor is the person who requires financial contributions to the family. The parent who requires the employed adult child to pay younger siblings' school fees. The family elder who requires festive contributions to the family event. The sibling who requires business support. The extraction is performed by direct demand, by invoking family need, or by punishing refusal.

The subject conforms by giving. What is extracted is tangible: money, goods, labour. The extraction transfers resources from the subject to the family. If nothing tangible transfers, it is not this triad.

The options the subject loses are concrete. A graduate who must support younger siblings loses the option to save, which is to say, loses the option to buy a house, to start a business, to take a risk. A worker who must contribute to the family event loses the option to spend that money on their own children. A relative who must support the family business loses the option to leave.

The witness is the person who knows of the financial extraction and does not intervene, or who themselves give to their own family. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the younger sibling whose school fees are being paid by the older sibling — the younger sibling benefits from the extraction but does not personally extract.

This role is unstable. The moment the younger sibling begins to demand school fees from the older sibling directly, they become an extractor. Most younger siblings drift into extraction by early adulthood, because the felt entitlement to family support grows with each received support.

3.8 Extraction Triad: Inheritance Channelling

The extractor is the person whose interest is served by the channelling of property, name, and status through blood lines. The patriarch who decides the family compound goes to the eldest son. The mother who decides her jewellery goes to the daughters. The family elder who decides the chieftaincy title goes to the senior male. The extraction is performed by writing the will, by giving the deathbed instruction, or by enforcing customary law.

The subject conforms by accepting the channelling. What is extracted is the inheritance itself — the property, name, and status that flows through the blood line to the exclusion of those outside the line.

The excluded lose what they would have received under a different arrangement.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The adopted child who is excluded from the will loses the option to inherit, which is to say, loses the option to a material foundation. The stepchild who is excluded loses the same. The daughter who is excluded under a patrilineal system loses the option to inherit her father's property, which is to say, loses the option to a secure widowhood.

The witness is the person who watches the channelling and does not intervene, or who themselves benefited from a channelling in their own family. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the family member who is not the extractor (the parent who wrote the will) but who benefits from the channelling — the eldest son who inherits the compound, the daughter who inherits the jewellery — without personally commanding the channelling.

3.9 Extraction Triad: Reproductive Capacity

The extractor is the person who requires the production of heirs to carry the family name and lineage. The parent who demands grandchildren. The husband who demands sons. The family elder who demands the lineage continue. The extraction is performed by asking 'when are you having children?', by punishing childlessness, or by arranging marriages for the purpose of reproduction.

The subject conforms by reproducing. What is extracted is the reproductive capacity itself — the body's ability to produce an heir, the years of fertility spent in pregnancy and childrearing, the physical and emotional cost of reproduction. The extraction is unique in that the resource is the subject's body.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The woman who is required to produce sons loses the option to a body that is not repeatedly pregnant, which is to say, loses the option to a career, to health, to a life. The childless woman who is pitied loses the option to a complete identity, which is to say, loses the option to be valued for herself. The person who does not want children loses the option to refuse without social punishment.

The witness is the person who watches the reproductive extraction and does not intervene, or who themselves performed the reproduction for the same family. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the family member whose lineage is being continued by the subject's reproduction — the husband whose name is being carried by the wife's pregnancy, the grandfather whose lineage is being extended by the son's fatherhood — but who does not personally command the reproduction.

Nascent forms of this system include: 'Blood is thicker than water', 'You can't choose your family', 'Family comes first', 'Real mother' / 'real father', 'Illegitimate child', 'Broken home', 'You don't know your roots', 'Stay together for the children', Pressure to marry, Pressure to have children, 'When are you having kids?', 'Your children should carry your name', 'You're not really family', Treating adopted children differently, Treating step-children differently, 'He's not your real brother', Pressuring singles about marriage, Cousin enforcement, 'Your family needs you', 'Why aren't you married yet?', 'But she's your mother', Disownment threats.

SECTION 3 · NAIVE APPROACH

3. The Disciplinary Domain

When the nine triads above link into networks, Kinship Normativity scales. The link can be hierarchical (the enforcer at one level is the subject at the level above) or community-based (the witness at one triad becomes the enforcer at another). Both forms are visible in every Nigerian institution that organises kinship.

4.1 Disciplinary Hierarchy — Nested Stars

A Disciplinary Hierarchy is a chain of nested triads. The enforcer at one level is the subject at the level above. Each middle position is simultaneously subject above and enforcer below. Kinship Normativity spreads through this form in every Nigerian family structure.

Peak Triad-Node

At the peak is the triad where the highest family authority — the patriarch or matriarch — enforces on the layer below. The peak enforcer has no adult above-them in this family hierarchy, so the enforcement is the purest expression of family authority at the top. The peak extracts loyalty, caretaking, financial support, inheritance channelling, and reproductive capacity from the layer below.

In the Nigerian family compound, the peak triad is the patriarch enforcing on his adult sons and their wives, or the matriarch (in matrifocal families) enforcing on her adult daughters and their husbands. In the extended family association, the peak is the family head (the ‘Baba’ or ‘Iya’ of the family union, conceptually) enforcing on the chairman, secretary, and members. In the family business, the peak is the founder enforcing on the successor son.

Middle Triad-Nodes

The middle nodes are where the chain’s character is clearest. Each middle enforcer is simultaneously subject above and enforcer below. The adult son who kneels for the patriarch in the morning demands kneeling from his own children in the afternoon. The senior wife who defers to the matriarch demands deference from the junior wife.

The middle is where Kinship Normativity reproduces. The child subject of today is the enforcer of tomorrow — as a parent, an uncle, an aunt, a grandparent. The middle position teaches the subject to want the position above, which means learning to enforce on those below. By the time the young family member becomes a parent, they have been disciplined by Kinship Normativity for two decades.

In the family compound, the middle nodes run from patriarch down through eldest son, younger sons, wives (ordered by marriage seniority), teenage children, younger children, and grandchildren. Each layer enforces blood, marriage, name, and filial piety on the layer below, and is in turn enforced on by the layer above.

Bottom Triad-Node

At the bottom is the triad where the lowest-ranked family enforcer enforces on the youngest or newest members. The eldest child enforcing on younger siblings. The senior wife enforcing on a new bride. The biological child enforcing on an adopted or step sibling. The bottom is where the system's violence is most concentrated.

The bottom node is also where the family hierarchy meets the community form. The eldest child who enforces on younger siblings is simultaneously the enforcer in a family hierarchy (above the siblings) and the subject in the same hierarchy (below the parents). The compound is a node in two directions: the eldest child extracts loyalty from the younger siblings what the parents extract from the eldest.

4.2 Disciplinary Community — Distributed Network

A Disciplinary Community is a distributed network. There is no peak, no chain of command. There is only circulation. The witness of one family triad becomes the enforcer, subject, or witness of another. Kinship Normativity spreads laterally through any person who has witnessed family enforcement without dissenting.

The Wedding Network

The wedding is the textbook Kinship Normativity community event. The couple's marriage is witnessed by hundreds of family members, friends, and acquaintances. The witnessing itself enforces the marriage standard: the couple has performed the publicly recognised kinship-formation ritual, and the witnesses have validated it by their presence.

The wedding also circulates the other triads. The mother of the bride who sees the groom's mother demand the bride take the groom's name files the demand away for her own future daughter-in-law. The unmarried cousin who watches the wedding is reminded, by every elder's question, that their turn is coming. The wedding is a community enforcement event.

The Funeral Network

The funeral is the other textbook Kinship Normativity community event. The deceased's lineage is recited by the officiating elder. The mourners witness the lineage, which validates the blood line. The inheritance is announced or contested. The eldest son is installed as the new family head. The funeral is a community enforcement of inheritance channelling and filial piety.

Religion amplifies this. The Pentecostal sermon on 'honouring your father and mother' circulates the filial piety triads across thousands of households in a single Sunday. The Imam's Friday sermon on family obligations does the same. No central command issues the order. The pattern circulates by repeated witnessing.

The Naming Ceremony and Christmas/Eid

The naming ceremony is a community enforcement of the family name standard and the reproductive capacity extraction triad. The child is given the family name before the community. The community witnesses the naming, which validates the lineage continuation.

Christmas and Eid gatherings are community enforcement of the loyalty and presence triads. The family member who does not attend is noted and questioned. The gathering itself is the extraction: the member's presence is the loyalty performance. The member's absence is the refusal the community punishes.

The Family Association

The extended family association — the Umuada in Igbo, the family union in Yoruba and other groups — is the most formal Kinship Normativity community. The association meets regularly, collects dues, enforces family discipline, and intervenes in disputes. The association is the lateral network that maintains kinship standards across households.

The Umuada (the daughters of the lineage, married and unmarried) is a particularly important community in Igbo systems. The Umuada intervenes in abuse cases, enforces succession rules, and protects the lineage's interests. The community is both an enforcement of Kinship Normativity and, in some cases, a partial check on its excesses — the framework treats both moves as analytically legible.

SECTION 4 · NAIVE APPROACH

4. The Structural Domain

Run the Ship of Theseus test. When the people in the initial Kinship Normativity triads are dead and replaced, when the networks are disbanded and reform, what is consistent? What outlives both individuals and groups? What forces new individuals and groups to re-form into the same patterns — not because anyone instructs them to, but because the residue makes any other pattern costly or invisible?

Kinship Normativity leaves all three residues. It is one of the most total systems in the framework, alongside Rankism and Adultism. Almost every Nigerian institution carries Bureaucracy, Stratification, and Classification from Kinship Normativity simultaneously. The sections below describe each.

5.1 Bureaucracy — Enduring Rules and Procedures

Kinship Normativity's bureaucracy is the codified kinship structure. The Marriage Act 1914 (Nigeria), modelled on the English Marriage Act, codified Christian monogamy as the only legally recognised marriage form for civil purposes. Customary and Islamic marriages were left to separate recognition, but the Marriage Act remained the default for inheritance, succession, and civil status.

The Matrimonial Causes Act 1970 codified divorce procedures. The Administration of Estates Laws of each state codified inheritance procedures, channelling property through blood and marriage to the exclusion of those outside. Birth registration codified the parent-child relation for civil purposes. Adoption proceedings codified the only legal route to non-biological parenting, with social worker reports and consent hurdles that blood parents never face.

Immigration family-reunification visas codified which relations count as 'family' for migration purposes — spouse and minor children, sometimes parents, rarely siblings, never friends. Pension survivor benefits codified which relations inherit the pension — spouse and minor children, no one else. Tax dependents codified which relations count for tax purposes. Each codification reinforces the blood and marriage standard.

The NYSC Act imposes a dependency rule for married women (who may be posted with their husbands) but not for married men — an asymmetry that overlaps with Cisheteropatriarchy (Chapter 5) but is rooted in the Kinship Normativity assumption that the wife follows the husband. The original 1914 authors are dead. The bureaucracy lives.

5.2 Stratification — Enduring Zero-Sum Rankings

Kinship Normativity's stratification is the daily experience of kinship rank in every institutional encounter. **Married vs single** — the married person ranks above the single person in social events, in

religious settings, in seating arrangements. **Parent vs non-parent** — the parent ranks above the non-parent in moral authority and social standing.

Blood vs chosen — the blood relative ranks above the chosen relation in legal recognition, medical decisions, and inheritance. **Eldest vs youngest in inheritance** — under many customary systems, the eldest son ranks above younger siblings in property succession. **Male vs female in patrilineal systems** — under patrilineal systems, the male heir ranks above the female heir in family property succession.

Heirs vs non-heirs — the recognised heir ranks above the non-heir in family standing and decision-making. The ranking is in the air; it does not need to be announced. Challenging it carries real costs: lost inheritance, social ostracism, sometimes physical safety.

The family event enforces stratification without anyone issuing an order. The patriarch sits at the head of the table. The eldest son sits next. The wives sit in order of marriage seniority. The children sit by age. The in-laws sit in places that mark their derivative status. The seating is the rank. Challenging the seating is challenging the family order.

5.3 Classification — Enduring Categorical Divisions

Kinship Normativity's classification is the set of categorical names that organise every Nigerian into kinship-status categories. **Legitimate** and **illegitimate** — the child born inside marriage is legitimate; the child born outside is not, with legal consequences under some systems.

Blood, step, and adopted — the three categories of child, with blood at the top and adopted at the bottom in social recognition, regardless of legal equality. **Married** and **single** — the universal adult pair, with married as the default and single as the deviant. **Parent** and **childless** — with parent as the default and childless as the failed.

Family and **non-family** — the boundary that decides who is invited to the wedding, who is consulted on the inheritance, who is informed of the illness, who is allowed at the deathbed. **Relative** and **stranger** — the same boundary in different language. **Heir** and **non-heir** — the boundary that decides who inherits what.

First wife and **second wife** in polygynous systems that survive customary recognition — with first wife ranking above second in social standing, decision-making, and sometimes inheritance. The classification does the work before any individual enforcer shows up. A person entering a family event is already classified; the enforcers do not need to demand deference because the category carries the deference inside it.

Classification is the most universal structural residue. Kinship Normativity's classification is foundational — the family/non-family boundary organises every other classification in the framework. Adultism (Chapter 3) ranks adults above children, but Kinship Normativity has already decided who is family and who is not, so the parent-child dyad is itself a kinship classification. Almost every matrix this framework will study borrows Kinship Normativity's grammar of legitimate and

illegitimate relation.

SECTION 5

5. The Hegemonic Domain: The Ascension Ritual

Is Kinship Normativity ascended? The test from Chapter 1: has it achieved Realism — the sense that it is the way reality works, that there is no alternative, that to challenge it is to challenge a hurricane? Has it retroactively rewritten history? Has it produced a stable Intrapersonal Domain?

Yes on all three. Kinship Normativity in Nigeria is ascended. It produces all three structural residues including Stratification (so Internalised Domination applies). It has working Canon and Practice mechanisms. The vast majority of Nigerians cannot imagine kinship outside blood and marriage — despite the fact that pre-colonial Nigerian kinship systems were markedly more flexible, and the fact that the current arrangement was installed by specific colonial legal instruments within living memory.

6.1 Canon — Rewriting History

Canon is the present belief that blood-and-marriage kinship has always been so. The origination of the structural residues — the Marriage Act 1914, the Administration of Estates Laws, the inheritance classification — has been forgotten. The average Nigerian now takes the blood-and-marriage kinship structure as natural, eternal, and without alternative.

What is forgotten? The Igbo female husband — the woman who married another woman and whose offspring carried her lineage, documented by Ifi Amadiume. The male daughter institution — the daughter who inherited the status and responsibilities of a son in families without sons. The Yoruba recognition of polygyny as a normal marriage form, with first wife, second wife, and subsequent wives each holding defined rights. The widespread practice of fostering — children raised by aunts, uncles, grandparents, or family friends as a normal feature of childhood, not a deviation.

Also forgotten: that the Marriage Act 1914 imported English Christian monogamy as the only legally recognised marriage form for civil purposes, displacing polygyny, female husbandship, and other indigenous arrangements from legal recognition. That the ‘illegitimate’ legal status was an English common law import, with no equivalent in pre-colonial Nigerian systems. That the Administration of Estates Laws channelled inheritance through British colonial probate procedures, displacing indigenous succession arrangements for civil purposes.

Internalised Domination

Canon produces Internalised Domination because Kinship Normativity produces Stratification. The eldest son’s felt entitlement to inherit the family compound and to make decisions for siblings is now natural, automatic, unquestionable. The matriarch’s felt entitlement to deference from daughters-in-law is natural. The parent’s felt entitlement to the adult child’s life choices is natural.

The patriarch who expects the eldest son to consult him before any major decision does not experience this as a demand. He experiences it as the natural order. The mother-in-law who expects the daughter-in-law to defer on household matters does not feel she is enforcing. She feels she is being accorded her due. The grandparent who expects the grandchild to be named after them does not feel they are extracting. They feel they are receiving what is owed.

The entitlement grows with repetition. The first time the eldest son made a decision without consulting the father, the father felt surprise. The hundredth time, the father feels outrage. The entitlement has been internalised so deeply that its non-fulfilment registers as injury.

Internalised Authority

Canon produces Internalised Authority in the family enforcer regardless of personal material gain. The mother who slaps the adult daughter for ‘disgracing the family’ gains nothing material from the slap. The slap does not extract labour or transfer resources. It enforces a standard — the family name — that the mother has been taught she has a right to enforce.

The uncle who publicly humiliates a nephew for ‘not attending the family event’ gains nothing material. The family elder who punishes the young relative for ‘marrying outside the family’s approval’ gains nothing material. The right to enforce feels natural, automatic, and legitimate. That is the Internalised Authority.

Internalised Oppression

Canon produces Internalised Oppression in the family subject and the family witness. The subject is taught that rebellion is impossible, immoral, or pointless. The witness is taught that dissent is dangerous, divisive, or unproductive. The teaching is silent; it is in the air.

The adult child who is told by a sibling ‘but she’s your mother’ is being disciplined by Canon. The unmarried adult who is told by a friend ‘you cannot refuse the family’ is being disciplined by Canon. The childless woman who is told by a relative ‘you will understand when you have your own’ is being disciplined by Canon. Each internalises the impossibility of refusal.

The deepest form of this is the family member who has absorbed Kinship Normativity so thoroughly that they enforce it on themselves. The adult child who says ‘I cannot abandon my family’ to explain why they remain in an abusive household. The childless woman who says ‘I am incomplete’ to explain why she has no identity outside motherhood. The unmarried adult who says ‘I am behind’ to explain why they feel like a failure. The rebellion-capable subject has become the self-policing subject.

6.2 Practice — Rewriting Reality

Practice is the second mechanism of the Ascension Ritual. The interpersonal triad is repeated, again and again, until it becomes habit. The family enforcer forgets they can choose not to enforce. The family subject forgets they can rebel. The family witness forgets they can dissent. The middle-aged parent who has been both subject and enforcer forgets they were ever either.

Pierre Bourdieu called this *habitus* — the sediment of repeated practice in the body, such that the social order no longer needs conscious compliance because it has become the body's default. The Nigerian child who learns to greet every relative in the prescribed order at every family event is undergoing Practice for Kinship Normativity. The body learns. The mind stops questioning.

By the time the child is twelve, the family event performance is reflex. They do not decide to greet the patriarch first. The body greets. By adulthood, the young person has performed the loyalty, caretaking, financial support, and presence triads so many thousands of times that the alternative — refusing the family claim, choosing the friend over the cousin, leaving the event — feels like a kind of amputation. The body has been trained. Practice has rewritten reality.

Death — Fast and Slow

Practice produces Death. Fast death in Kinship Normativity is spectacular: honour killings of those who marry outside family approval, with notable cases in some Hausa and Tiv contexts. Witchcraft accusations against widows to dispossess them of family property, especially in parts of the South-East and South-South. 'Missing heirs' violence — the killing of a rival claimant to prevent them contesting the inheritance.

Violence against those who leave the family religion — the convert from Islam to Christianity (or vice versa) who is killed by family for apostasy, with documented cases in the North. ALUU-style killings where the mob enforces 'family dignity' against suspected offenders. The lynching of the 'disrespectful' youth by an elders' mob, often kinship-coded.

Slow death in Kinship Normativity is quiet. Chronic stress from constant family obligations — the eldest daughter who has not slept eight hours in twenty years because she is managing her mother's household, her own household, and her younger siblings' crises. Erosion of self in service of family name — the adult son who gave up his chosen career to take over the family business and reaches 50 unable to remember what he wanted.

The childless woman's chronic social devaluation — the woman who is pitied at every family event, who is excluded from the mothers' circle at church, who is asked 'what are you waiting for?' until she stops attending. The trapped spouse's depression — the woman or man who cannot leave the marriage because 'for the children' and 'for the family', and whose body breaks down under the strain. The 'black sheep' who is slowly pushed out of inheritance and recognition — the LGBTQ+ Nigerian disowned by family with no legal recourse, who loses not only emotional support but material foundation.

Ruth Wilson Gilmore's definition applies: Kinship Normativity produces group-differentiated vulnerability to premature death. The group is 'those outside the blood-and-marriage standard' — the childless, the unmarried, the adopted, the chosen family, the LGBTQ+, the disowned. The premature death is fast (honour killing, witchcraft accusation, apostasy killing, missing heirs) or slow (stress, devaluation, depression, exclusion). Every ascended matrix kills. Kinship Normativity kills those whose kinship does not fit.

SECTION 6

6. When Did Kinship Normativity Rewrite History?

The framework's historical question: when did Kinship Normativity rewrite history in popular living memory, such that the average Nigerian cannot recall a time when its structural residue was not present? This is not a history of how Kinship Normativity was built. It is a diagnosis of when the building was forgotten.

Pre-colonial Nigerian kinship systems had blood and marriage, but both were calibrated differently. The Igbo female husband — the woman who married another woman and whose offspring carried her lineage — was a recognised kinship form. The male daughter institution allowed daughters to inherit the status of sons in families without sons. Polygyny was recognised across most of the North and parts of the South. Fostering was normal — children raised by aunts, uncles, grandparents, or family friends as a feature of childhood.

Colonial codification displaced these arrangements from legal recognition. The Marriage Act 1914 imported English Christian monogamy as the only legally recognised marriage form for civil purposes. Customary and Islamic marriages were left to separate recognition, but the Marriage Act remained the default for inheritance, succession, and civil status. The English common law category of 'illegitimate' was imported, with no equivalent in pre-colonial systems.

The Administration of Estates Laws channelled inheritance through British colonial probate procedures. The Matrimonial Causes Act 1970 codified divorce on the English model. Adoption proceedings codified the only legal route to non-biological parenting, displacing the informal fostering that had been normal. By the 1960s, the colonial definitions had displaced the indigenous arrangements in legal recognition, though the indigenous forms continued in practice.

The tipping point in popular living memory: **circa 1914**. For Nigerians born after 1890 — the colonial-subject generation and after — Kinship Normativity has 'always been' in its legal form. They cannot recall a time when the Marriage Act definition was not the legal default. The pre-colonial kinship generation (born ~1860s–1880s) was the last to have living memory of the indigenous arrangements as the legal default. By 1914, the Marriage Act had displaced them for civil purposes, though they survived in customary practice.

What changed in that moment? Two things. First, the Marriage Act 1914 standardised the English Christian monogamous marriage as the legal default, so that the colonial definition of 'marriage' became the legal definition for every Nigerian in civil matters. Second, the colonial courts began to enforce this definition in inheritance and succession cases, so that the first generation to inherit under the new regime reached inheritance age in the 1920s and 1930s. By 1960, the question 'is the blood-and-marriage kinship structure natural?' had stopped being asked in popular memory.

SECTION 7

7. Fill in the Blank: A Self-Examination

The framework asks two questions of every subject of every ascended matrix. The blanks are for you. They are not rhetorical. The point of the framework is not to understand Kinship Normativity in the abstract. It is to locate yourself inside it, so that the next time the triad assembles around you — or around someone whose kinship does not fit — you can see it.

Question 1: When did Kinship Normativity rewrite your reality?

When did the system teach you that you could not rebel? The moment was: _____. The year was: _____. The family member who first made you feel that challenging them was impossible was: _____. The place was: _____. What you wanted to say but did not was: _____. What you did instead was: _____. What you told yourself about why you did not say it was: _____. The kinship performance you assumed in that moment was: _____. The form of address you used was: _____. What you lost, in that moment, that you have not got back since, was: _____. The family relation at the centre of the moment was: _____.

Question 2: How is Kinship Normativity causing your Death?

How is the system shortening your life right now? The form of Death I am most afraid of from Kinship Normativity is (fast/slow): _____. The specific way it is happening in my body is: _____. (For example: the chronic stress from years of family obligations; the insomnia from years of swallowing words I wanted to say to my parent; the loss of confidence from years of being told I am incomplete without children; the breakdown I had in 20__ that I have never fully recovered from; the relationship I lost because I could not stop performing filial piety at home; the medical diagnosis I now live with because the stress had nowhere else to go; the inheritance I lost because I was not the 'right' kind of family.) The matrix's name for what is happening to me is: _____. My own name for it is: _____.

If you filled in the blanks honestly, you have just located yourself inside Kinship Normativity. The next time the triad assembles — the next time the family demands, the next time the body performs, the next time the 'real family' standard is invoked — you will be able to see the system moving through you. That sight is the beginning of abolition. And if you are now the enforcer in the triad, the sight is also the beginning of your refusal to enforce.

SECTION 8

8. Endnotes & References

References cited inline in this chapter, in APA format. The list is the set of sources the framework is directly borrowing from in this installment. Cumulative references from Chapters 1, 2, and 3 are also included where they recur.

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Coming Next

Chapter 5 will take up Cisheteropatriarchy — the system that ranks cisgender, heterosexual men above everyone else, enforces gender roles and sexual norms, and extracts labour, deference, and reproductive capacity from women, gender-nonconforming people, and LGBTQ+ Nigerians. Cisheteropatriarchy overlaps with Kinship Normativity at the marriage dyad (Chapter 4) and with Rankism at the male/female rank (Chapter 2). The framework separates them so that the gender and sexuality logic specifically can be studied and dismantled.

If you are reading this chapter as part of the framework in progress, the order continues: Chapter 6 is Religious Dominance / Sectarianism, Chapter 7 is Enclosure, Chapter 8 is Productivism, and so on through the Fundamental Matrices. Each chapter follows the same template established in Chapters 2, 3, and 4. The naive approach in the first three domains. The Ascension Ritual in the fourth. The historical memory trace. The fill-in-the-blank. The endnotes. The pattern is now set.